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EDUCATION

“Professor Subramanian is Being Targeted Because She Dared to Call Out the Relationship of the Indian Caste System with Vedic Mathematics”

Ohio State mathematics education professor Theodore Chao's eyewitness testimony of Dr. Jayasree Subramanian's expulsion from the 15th International Congress on Mathematical Education in Sydney — removed from the conference for questioning the caste politics embedded in a session promoting Vedic mathematics.

BY THEODORE CHAO

Theodore Chao's Testimony of Professor Jayasree Subramanian's Actions in the Session “Reviving Ancient Wisdom: Vedic Mathematics for Modern Learning” Facilitated by Ashish Arora

This testimony was written in defense of Professor Jayasree Subramanian, who was expelled from the recently held 15th ICME in Sydney due to the incident described above. Chao's testimony has been widely circulated through academic circles, & is largely responsible for shedding light on the controversy.

My name is Theodore Chao and I am a professor of mathematics education at the Ohio State University. I am honored to be an invited speaker at the International Congress of Mathematics Education (ICME) conference in Sydney, Australia in 2024. This is my second ICME conference and I came because I love hearing and discussing global perspectives of mathematics education and learning to eradicate past injustices. Yesterday, July 12, I attended a 9:00 AM session titled, 'Reviving Ancient Wisdom: Vedic Mathematics for Modern Learning', facilitated by Professor Ashish Arora of I. K. Gujral Punjab Technical University.

I attended the session because I was interested in cultural ways of thinking about mathematics and mathematics teaching practices, particularly ones that come from non-Eurocentric backgrounds. My limited understanding of Indian mathematics history made me curious to attend this session and I did so with an open mind, without assumptions that there might be issues of injustice and oppression within what would be presented as Vedic mathematics.

Personally, I found the session to be quite disappointing, but not terrible. Professor Arora only briefly spoke about the origins of Vedic mathematics and the different mathematicians who were considered Vedic mathematicians in India. I wish he had spent more time on speaking about and engaging us in discussion about the cultural history of mathematics, as this was supposed to be a workshop session. But he quickly glossed through this history in about 15 or 20 minutes.

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EDUCATION

Indian Professor Expelled from ICME’15 for Caste-Critical Comments During Vedic Math Session

On 12th July 2024, Professor Jayasree Subramanian was physically escorted from ICME-15 in Sydney and stripped of her registration after raising questions about caste and Brahminical supremacy during a session on Vedic mathematics — a report on the incident, the testimony that circulated in its wake, and what it says about academic gatekeeping.

BY MOULI SHARMA

Professor Jayasree Subramanian was reportedly physically escorted away from the convention center by security guards for the points she made during the session, as well as had her badge & registration revoked without due procedure, apparently because “other participants” found her points “threatening.”



Source: SRM University (AP)

Photo: Mouli Sharma

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Then, Professor Arora introduced various mathematics procedures framed as particular aspects of Vedic mathematics. I would have found these procedures fascinating if we had time to unpack them, play with them, and discuss their histories. Instead, Professor Arora jumped into examples and specific details about the way to use these procedures in isolated ways, unconnected to real-world mathematics. I tried to follow along with various ways that he presented specific values within algorithms that would lead to multiplication. Personally, I found these examples to be quite boring because Professor Arora seemed to be lecturing and just walking through the examples quickly without really interacting with the audience. In fact, I even intervened to move the whiteboard he was using to a space that was more well-lit and visible to the rest of the room to make this lecture a little more engaging to the audience. I was disappointed because it felt very much like a traditional (not in a good way) college mathematics lecture, one in which the professor did not seem interested in connecting with the audience or even listening to what the audience was thinking.

During the lecture, I, as well as the woman sitting next to me, were having trouble following the mathematics that was being presented. We felt frustrated at the pace of the presentation. And we wondered if there were typos on the slides because we had trouble generating the same answers that were presented. Professor Arora did not seem to acknowledge this or want to engage the audience about our understanding. This was frustrating as I felt that a pause for discussion would have been pedagogically appropriate.

About 45 minutes into the session (9:45 AM), I heard one of the participants in the room ask if there would be room for discussion. The speaker answered that, yes, there would be time for discussion and just kept continuing lecturing. I noticed that me and the other participants around me all seemed disappointed that we did not start a discussion at that time.

When there were 15 minutes left in this 1.5-hour session (10:15 AM), Professor Arora opened up time for discussion. By this point, I had given up any attempt to follow along with the mathematics being presented. Professor Jayasree Subramanian, who was sitting a row behind me, raised her hand and was called on.

Professor Subramanian stood up and raised a few, well-organized points.

First, Professor Subramanian raised the point that the presenter was presenting Indian mathematics as one of only two mathematics cultures, European mathematics being the other. She questioned why Professor Arora did not acknowledge the other forms of mathematics such as Chinese or Egyptian or Inca mathematics and mentioned that not acknowledging other mathematical cultures is problematic.

Indian Professor Expelled from ICME’15 for Caste-Criti · CONTINUED FROM PAGE 1

25th July 2024: On the 12th of July, 2024, two days before the completion of the 15th International Congress on Mathematical Education in Sydney, math & math education professor at the Department of Mathematics, SRM University (AP) Dr. Jayasree Subramanian was expelled from the conference due to, ironically, speaking out at a session based on Indian approaches to mathematical education, specifically the ‘Vedic Approach’.

Second, Professor Subramanian brought up that Professor Arora did not mention that the idea of Vedic mathematics actually centers the idea of Brahmin supremacy within the unjust caste system that still pervades India today. Personally, I did not know much about this background. So, I appreciated that Professor Subramanian brought this up. For a conference like ICME, I feel we should be talking heavily about humanity and injustice, particularly within mathematics education. So this information helped me situate and understand culturally the role and space of what is labeled as Vedic mathematics.

Subramanian raised a few points when the floor was opened for discussion, including that of the Vedic system’s relationship with caste and Brahminical supremacy. “First, Professor Subramanian raised the point that the presenter was presenting Indian mathematics as one of only two mathematics cultures, European mathematics being the other. She questioned why Professor Arora did not acknowledge the other forms of mathematics such as Chinese or Egyptian or Inca mathematics and mentioned that not acknowledging other mathematical cultures is problematic.

Third, Professor Subramanian mentioned that some of the books and articles that were cited about Vedic mathematics in the introduction had been discredited. Professor Subramanian even mentioned that one the cited authors had disavowed the idea that a Vedic mathematics even exists. I appreciated this insight, as it revealed to me the ways propaganda and revisionist history are not found only in the mathematics context of the USA, but are universal. I also appreciated learning about the controversy over the ways that mathematics in India is situated and talked about. And I especially appreciated the connection back to the unjust caste system, particularly because it reinforced the little that I knew about the ways that Brahmin ideology often positions itself as the one and only true caste, and thereby the official holders of mathematics knowledge.

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INTERNATIONAL

“It’s Okay, They’re Just Playing With Us”: Games of the Gun from the Occupied West Bank

A report on a practice documented in the occupied West Bank, where soldiers from Israeli settlements use laser sights from sniper rifles to play ‘statue’ with Palestinian families — forcing people to freeze on command. On the mundane, psychological texture of long-term military occupation.

BY MOULI SHARMA

Post ‘67, Pockets of Palestine Surrounded by Israeli Settlements Have Learnt to Live with a Strange & Psychologically Grotesque Consequence of Long-Term Military Occupation: Bored Soldiers.

16th July 2024, New Delhi : On October 22nd, 2023, a mere two weeks after October 7th, a video was posted to TikTok showing a man describing a visit to his sister’s home in a small Hebron village called Beit Ummar, & their life along the occupied West Bank. He described a game the soldiers played with Palestinian families in the area, explained to him by his own nephew and brother-in-law. It was a game of ‘statue’, as people who grew up in parts of the world not under active warfare would recall playing, where a group of runners freezes up in response to a commanding catcher, yelling out the preferred variant of the band of neighborhood rascals: Ice! Freeze! Lock! Tag! Statue!

In Beit Ummar, the command is not heard but seen, in the form of laser pointers from sniper rifles. And the soldiers always chase.

“I visited my sister in her home in Beit Ummar, which is a village in Hebron. Sitting atop a hill their beautiful home was surrounded by three Israeli settlements. I woke up in the middle of the night with my nephew & brother-in-law standing next to me - they’d spotted several laser pointers pointing into the house from one of the settlements that are nearby. And when I asked them what was happening, they told me to stay lying in bed because this is often a game that settlers played with them. The “game” was laser pointers from sniper rifles in the house at all times, so they knew that they could take a shot whenever they wanted.” - @candide_freeman on Tik Tok, posted 22nd October 2023, with 5 likes & 1 share.

Journalist Leila Warah (@leila.shw on Instagram) describes this phenomenon as a common, almost ordinary occurrence in areas like Beit Ummar, which are populated by native residents leftover after the Six Day War back in ‘67, outnumbered & surrounded by Israeli settlements. An evolved form of settler violence, born less from malice or urgency, and - rather terrifyingly - more from boredom.

Areas with a larger displaced population - & consequently stronger military presence - on the other hand, like refugee camps & epicenters of post-October 7th attacks see their own versions of these ‘second-person shooter games’. Drones flying up to balconies & uttering eerily human threats in distinctly unhuman voices (“We are in wartime,” says a drone to an elderly man while hovering outside his balcony. “We advise you to take caution. And take care of your kids. Whoever thinks of doing something, we will get to him. We are in wartime...”), remote-controlled guns that seem to track movement; air-dropped aid that kills.

In Aida Refugee Camp, where Leila Warah lives & works, daily life looks very different from that in Beit Ummar. Like most refugee camps, the overwhelming presence around Aida is not that of settlers but of soldiers. The UNRWA recognises 58 Palestinian camps (not including 10 more formed after ‘67) across the occupied land, & even among them, Aida is highly surveilled .

At the entrance of this camp sits a remote-controlled gun. One that points at every passerby, & is triggered by untested artificial intelligence .

“Soldiers are bored. They’re just maybe sitting there & they kinda want to mess with you. You feel like a hamster sitting in a test wheel. They’re just playing with you.” - Leila Warah, AJStream on Al Jazeera, 16th July, 2024.

She says it like it bores her.

Because of course, in a state that’s been on lockdown for 75 years, it isn’t just the soldiers who have nothing to do.

In Siri Miri , a Palestinian short film about youth & boredom in a 21st-century apartheid nation directed by Luay Awwad , a sniper rifle being pointed at two teenagers enjoying a bonfire is treated as little more than a joke, and one that’s low-hanging fruit at that. The scene seems to jab at the casualty of the encounter, glossing over the drama of a near-death experience in favor of that of a torched Friday night plan, as if the snipers are just mischievous old coots outside of the frame, teasing our boys as they skulk off in defeat. A cartoonish nemeses, with cartoonish gravity.

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To me, these comments were great ways to start a conversation. Professor Subramanian spoke loudly so that the whole room could hear her. And she spoke with passion. Her comments seemed respectful and in line with opening up academic discourse.

After this, another participant stood up to speak. This participant mentioned that there was a space to engage in a critical unpacking of Vedic mathematics. But that, perhaps that critical conversation was not appropriate at this session. Then, because it was now 10:30 AM, the session was finished and we all walked outside.

After the session was over, I saw Professor Subramanian outside and I thanked her for her comments. I felt that without her comments, I would’ve left this session frustrated because it felt very much like a mathematics lecture and not a mathematics education workshop. I also felt that there were a number of ideas that came up in the session that were glossed over quickly, such as the role of the Vedic mathematicians, the connections of the Vedic mathematics to real-world mathematics, or even the ways that these ideas connected to mathematics teaching or teacher education.

Without Professor Subramanian’s comments, I would’ve been frustrated and felt that I had spent an hour and a half in what was supposed to be a workshop and not really learned anything at all. But Professor Subramanian’s comments helped connect the content presented to the realm of mathematics education and helped me better understand the sociopolitical space of how Vedic mathematics is situated.

Through Professor Subramanian’s comments, I learned that the term Vedic is problematic, and that there are issues of power and caste and hierarchies deeply involved in this way of thinking about mathematics. This lens helped me better reflect on this session and the ways it connects to larger issues within our field of mathematics education globally.

In no way did I find anything that Professor Subramanian said to be antagonistic or confrontational. Nor did I feel that there was any risk of violence or threats in the room. In fact, I felt that the conversations that came about because of Jayasree’s comments led to a better conversation for everybody in the room because it helped connect the content to mathematics education.

I have since learned that Professor Subramanian was expelled from the ICME conference because of her comments in this session. To me, this decision feels unjust and unnecessarily harsh. From what I saw, Professor Subramanian was bringing up points to better connect this workshop to the goals of ICME. Without her comments, this would have been an inappropriate mathematics lecture that had no connection to ICME.

Even though I am an invited speaker and member of the ICME community, I ended up spending the rest of my Saturday missing sessions of the conference that I would have liked to have attended and participated in because I learned about this injustice to Professor Subramanian.

"It's Okay, They're Just Playing With Us": Games of th · CONTINUED FROM PAGE 2

The scene speaks to the peaceful global resident something so foreign they can do little more than scoff at the absurdity of it all; offering sympathy where it isn't needed, & will be unflinchingly rejected. 'Feel sorry that the fucker ruined our bonfire again,' Awwad says in his film. 'There's nothing else for you to feel sorry about.'

What is interesting about Siri Miri is that contrary to popular understanding of freedoms & everyday life in Palestine before October 7th, the film was released in 2021, long before Netanyahu's military campaign in the region, & the degree of infrastructural control shown in it (water, movement, electricity, rations, safety) is far from the worst exercised by Israel in the West Bank, either in the past or in the present.

"Take care of your kids." - Israeli Drone Outside Palestinian Family's Balcony, @yumna.hp on TikTök, 3rd December 2023.

There's a sadistic sense of humour with which the Israeli military has come to operate in Palestine, a humour that could only have evolved from a relationship of violence, control, & colonisation that has lasted half a century. A disturbing intimacy to the familiarity with which Israeli soldiers point their guns at Palestinians; a reverse Stockholm syndrome between keeper & kept, as if the terror they cause is but a drawn-out abusive marriage they don't recognise themselves outside of. 'What do they mean they don't want to be tortured & killed? What do they mean they don't want to have their homes stolen & bombed? What do they mean they don't love my boot on their neck?'

What do you mean you don't want to play?

Based on Leila Warah's interview aired alongside curated TikTok posts on The Stream hosted by Anelise Borges on Al Jazeera (English) on 16th July 2024. Report compiled by The Voice Express.



GENDER

Labyarinth

The first instalment of Labyarinth — TVE's series on bodies, desire, and the structures that keep us ignorant of both. Using Netflix's 'Lust Stories' and R.E. Gross's 'Vagina Obscura' as entry points, an essay on what Indian society still refuses to say when it refuses to talk about sex.

BY MOULI SHARMA

F*cking the Obscurity Out of the Vagina Obscura

Pilot: A New Series

Five years ago, after a well intentioned attempt at progressivism by multibillion dollar media conglomerate and part time streaming corporation Netflix came out in the form of a four part anthology film titled 'Lust Stories' to destigmatize sex and sexual desire in Indian society, the comedy group All India Bakchod released a promotional video on YouTube that will end up constituting part of this essay's vertebrae. Lust Stories was released in a social environment from whence India hasn't really progressed much further along in half a decade; indeed it is possible, it has regressed. Consider Uttarakhand's landmark Uniform Civil Code, which legally subjects live-in relationships between consenting adults in the state to government approval, or the crackdown of Hindu nationalist Bharatiya Janata Party along with the litany of its even more radical fringe sister-groups all over the country on 'Love Jihad.' So it is telling, that of the conversations that the film received praise and acclaim for starting, by far the one that received the most attention (and even more screen time) was that about none other than the great elusive female orgasm itself.

Graphics by Shruti Patel

Among the more typical connotations and Greek/Kafkaesque heritage of the labyrinth lies a definition of the word tucked into the tortuous folds of alternate dictionary meanings: an anatomical structure built of bends and twists and turns.

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Two years ago a wonderful book called the Vagina Obscura (R. E. - wait for it - Gross) set out to solve this mystery, beginning her quest in - take a wild, wild, labyrinthian guess - Greece. A redrawing of women's bodies by women themselves, of finally knowing the parts of us for which we 'should've been ashamed'. A Kaan Khajura hidden away in the winding corners of an ear canal; a G Spot hidden away, in us.

Two years later still and the Vagina is little less obscure. Orgasm ratios are still in despair, husbands still cannot make their wives come and psychologists are bending over backwards to invent new psychological phalluses to fuck women over with now that Freud's have gone moldy and unpopular. The complexity of the female anatomical system has become deified, a mythological entity like Red Wine and Wrestling. And there is no clearer identifier of a myth that has outlived its utility, than when it starts getting in the way of desire.

Footnotes

1 At least they didn't name it 'Honest Indian Lust'.

2 Here's how the first of these conversations goes: "Excuse me, Miss, could you point me in the direction of the Woman's Pleasure Point?" "Oh, sure. It's pretty simple: go straight ahead from here, you'll get to the Vagina Toll point, where you'll have to get consent, a personality assessment etc to pass. After that you'll reach the Labia Minora gate - drive carefully there, it's really slippery. Then if you reach the Fallopian Flyover... you need to turn back, you've gone too far. And after turning back just drive around a bit, a little forward backward forward backward that's it that's it that's the spot right there right there keep it going ye oh yes oh - well if it rains you're there."

3 Here's the second: "Excuse me, could you tell me where the Male Pleasure Point would be?" "There's a big building up ahead." "That's it?" "Yeah."



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